

Pest Control

The occurrence of Adware and associated pests over a 28 day period

Pest	Count
Adware	189,319
Peer-to-peer	65,103
Spyware	35,553
Spyware Cookie	17,134
Browser Helper Object	16,839
Worm	2,919
Hijacker	1,447
Dialer	1,193
RAT	797
Key Logger	602

Source: PestPatrol.com

home page later, these tools will reset it again without asking.

At the heart of the problem is the lack of awareness. These applications hide within the dozens of programs that run when you start your PC. Trying to manage the processes running in Windows, or the programs starting up with Windows, has always been difficult. Most executables have cryptic file names, leaving you clueless as to which can safely be disabled.



Long license agreements contain fine print

Help is at hand

All users should have good anti-virus software and firewalls installed. One would think this is enough to keep you secure, but it's hardly adequate. Some of the better anti-virus software will effectively detect, and remove a lot of the known Trojans. Other types of spyware are ignored by these tools, making them ineffective. Firewalls should prevent spyware from sending out any information, but they only feature program control, which allows you to specify which programs have access to the Internet. This only works when there is a dedicated spyware program, with a separate process attempting to send out information. Spyware that piggy backs on popular applications may use their host application to transmit whatever data they need to. Spyware creators can capitalise on this fact to get past your firewall. Since the combination of anti-virus and firewall are not enough, a dedicated anti-spyware system is required.

Removal of spyware is never a hundred per cent accurate, and it's nearly impossible to verify. Some applications that come bundled with spyware, do not work when the spyware elements are removed. You need to re-install the application—which just re-installs the spyware. Other more intelligent applications re-install the spyware automatically when you run them.

How we tested

All our testing was done on a 2.4 GHz Pentium 4 CPU running Windows XP Professional. We selected sev-

eral applications known to contain spyware, and installed them all on the target PC (see box, 'The Usual Suspects'). We then installed one of the anti-spyware tools and ran it without changing any of the default options. The number of spyware objects found was recorded, and then the tool was permitted to clean out whatever it found. We then attempted to run the applications containing spyware. The process was repeated for the remaining anti-spyware tools. All the tools tested were the freely downloadable versions that were available at their respective Web sites. Full versions can be purchased online.

Spybot



PepiMK Software's Spybot is a comprehensive Adware and Spyware remover, at the best price ever—it's free! The installation is easy enough, and is fairly quick. You get a warning message telling you that removing some spyware may prevent some of your other software from functioning or could go against their licensing policies. The program's interface takes a minute to figure out, but is very straightforward in its use. Using all the default options, scanning for spyware is very quick, taking less than a minute on our test rig. The scan showed up 34 objects and listed them along with their paths. Clicking on an object brings up a very comprehensive description of what it is—the type of spyware it is, the possible level of risk, what that program or file does to your system, and even an overview of the company's privacy policy. This is more than enough for you to make an informed choice of what to keep, and what should go. In this regard, Spybot provided more information and made it more accessible than any of the other tools tested here. However, Spybot failed to detect some elements of spyware from Kontiki, Cydoor and WurldMedia. Any Spyware applications that are running during the scan are cleared out after a restart.



Spybot: Searching and destroying!

Price: Free ■ Web site: <http://spybot.eon.net.au/> ■ Grade: A-

The Usual Suspects

KaZaA Media Desktop: A popular file sharing application that contains Cydoor and WhenU's SaveNow adware and spyware.

Morpheus: A file sharing application that has My Search Bar and Shopping Community programs bundled with it. These are not removed, even when you uninstall Morpheus.

Download Accelerator Plus (DAP): An adware supported download manager which shows its own banner ads.

CNet's Download Manager: An application, powered by the Kontiki Delivery Network, that integrates with download.com for downloading large files.

Weather Bug: This program gives you the local weather, along with forecasts for the days ahead. It is supported by Gator.



*see offer on page 94-95